Bhutan is our closest neighbour and we have vital stakes in its stability and progress. Therefore, my first goodwill visit as COAS was to Bhutan. The traditional and warm welcome by the then King Jigme Singye Wangchuk and his government, followed by meaningful discussions, made the visit memorable. In 2005, Crown Prince Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuk chose not to go for higher studies to Harvard or any other university abroad and instead preferred to do the year-long course at the National Defence College (NDC) at New Delhi, when I was the army chief. I found him to be one of the most wise, mature, clear-headed and articulate young men that I had met in years. I invited him to the Army House on a number of occasions, as both of us developed a close rapport and a shared vision of military cooperation and future challenges to our security. During his visit to the NDC in October 2010, he fondly remembered his time doing the course and stated, 'I feel it was destiny that gave me the most wonderful opportunity to spend my final year before becoming the king, in India.' Today, Bhutan is on the path of consolidating its democratic institutions and developing its infrastructure and other fields such as roads, hydro-power, IT, industry and agriculture, with some help from India. Camps established by Indian insurgent groups like the ULFA and the National Democratic Front of Bodoland of Assam were destroyed in 2003 in operations conducted by the Royal Bhutan Army in coordination with the Indian Army, and even now they are being denied safe havens there.

The year 2009 witnessed a major change in the bilateral relations between Bangladesh and India, consequent to the establishment of the multi-party democratic government led by Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina. Landmark agreements were signed in January 2010 between the two countries for mutual benefit. India has committed US $1 billion for infrastructural development in Bangladesh. Enhanced cooperation on security issues, particularly action against terrorist groups who have established their bases in Bangladesh, has had a great impact on downsizing of terrorist organizations like the